

Episode 84: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative! *Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes (Part 5 and 1/2)

From last week through this week, the WBC (World Baseball Classic) has been at the centre of my life - everything in my day was decided according to game broadcast times. I ended up skipping preview screenings and having meeting times shifted, so my apologies > To all concerned parties

Thanks to everyone's cooperation (laughs), Japan magnificently won the championship! (←I hate the expression "Samurai JAPAN" - it's lame (laughs))

But you know, that final game - no matter who won or lost, it was such a good game that it didn't matter! Truly the game of the century! When we got tied in the bottom of the 9th, I was actually a bit happy. Partly thinking "ah, this is the real thrill of baseball," and "ah, I can watch this battle a little longer!"

I feel like I was shown something I'll probably never forget for the rest of my life.

Oh, and also...

"I'm so glad I bought a big TV! Long live digital terrestrial!"

Now then.

Casshern Sins Colour Design Notes - this week covers episodes 19-21 of the main story (←It still won't end (laughs)).

Episode 19: "Believing in the Flower That Lives in the Heart"

Script: Yoshida Reiko / Storyboard & Direction: Nakayama Naomi / Animation Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

After finding one answer to her inner conflict in episode 18, Lyuze lost the mission she had been given to "kill Casshern," and having lost her emotional support, she returns to reality and faces her own "ruin" and its terror. Casshern who lives eternally, Lyuze whose ruin progresses. The words of female warrior Helene pursue such feelings.

In my mind, episode 19 was the beginning of the final sprint - I approached it with that feeling.

Director Nakayama said "I want to colour according to Lyuze's feelings," so in addition to scene-by-scene colour changes, I tried adding purple to character shadows during battles and according to emotional dominance, and for scenes inside caves where she suppresses her heart and speaks matter-of-factly, I created monochromatic colours with as little variation as possible.

From the pre-dawn rain battle, Helen's death marks dawn breaking all at once, and simultaneously doubt disappears from Lyuze's heart. I thought if we could beautifully create that series of scenes, we'd win - with that thinking, I give myself 100% full marks (laughs).

Incidentally, the cut where Helene dies was wonderful work by colour direction Kohinata-san. I just conveyed a rough image and let Kohinata-san create the colours - it was a special cut.

Episode 20: "For Whom Do Flowers Bloom"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: eunyoung CHOI / Animation Director: eunyoung CHOI / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Finally reaching Luna's clinic. Reunion with Down. And Luna. However, the actual Luna was a cold existence far from the "healing" image. Yet Down still serves such a Luna.

Director and key animator/animation director Eunyoung-san.

Actually I didn't know her at all. I hadn't seen her previous work either. However, during the art board meeting with Yukie-san and the three of us, I became a huge fan of hers mid-meeting (laughs). It had been a long time since I was so excited about meeting content. Furthermore, at the colour direction meeting, leaving colour direction Akimoto-san behind, Eunyoung-san and I got carried away together, and the product of that was episode 20's edgy colouring (laughs).

I thought to make daytime not much different from usual Casshern-like colouring, but nights with mysterious expression that might make you think "unrealistic?"

When I read the scenario, I had thought "In episode 20, couldn't we achieve a feeling like 'it's very realistic but goes beyond that and reality flies away?'" and that exactly matched Eunyoung-san's sensibility - it "clicked!" and fit perfectly in my mind.

The flow was: first Eunyoung-san, Yukie-san and I met about art boards. From the images conveyed there, Yukie-san drew art boards, and I created scene-by-scene colours on top of those boards. When roughly complete, Eunyoung-san and I worked out details with samples in front of us. Based on the colour design approved there, we then built up detailed cut-by-cut meetings with the colour direction staff.

Eunyoung-san would critique my scene design where I assembled colour samples on art boards, and I'd respond by bringing up new ideas - that kind of exchange. Basically that's the process for any episode, but somehow the exchange with Eunyoung-san was instantaneous and incredibly dense, and that exchange itself was, wow, fun!

Was it the director's decision to assign Eunyoung-san to episode 20? Production PD Fujio-san's decision? Either way, it was a perfect match. I want to work with Eunyoung-san again! (laughs)

Episode 21: "Paradise of Disappointment"

Script: Yoshida Reiko / Storyboard: Miyashita Shinpei / Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Kiyomaru Satoru, Saito Tadashi, Takanya, Tsuchikawa Norika, Sakurai Masaaki, Kitao Masaru / Colour Direction: Komada Noriko

Casshern and others who have lost faith in Luna. There they're joined by Ouji, who tells them "Luna once gave 'healing' called 'lifespan (death)' to immortal robots." Meanwhile, Luna is now spreading "immortality (eternal life)" under the name of "healing." A city of robots living hedonistically after being granted immortality. Down who died for Luna. Lyuze who refuses Luna's "healing" while carrying ruin. Various things weigh on Casshern, and from his conflict he gets destroyed by Dio's forces without resistance...

Episode 21 was the series' second outsourced production episode. Studio Fantasia handled animation through finishing.

As a contrast to episode 20, I kept this episode to designing scenes relatively simply by matching scene backgrounds. Actually, I was planning to do lots of various things in the following episode 22.

For the hedonistic city scenes where they live after gaining immortality, director Kimura's explanation was "It's riot of colour!" However, *Casshern Sins* had been killing colours and creating low-saturation screens all along, so I couldn't quite get the balance of "riot of colour" right - "So how much colour am I allowed to use? (sweat)" The art staff seemed to have the same issue (laughs).

During rush checking, incredibly flashy stones appeared on screen, and seeing that made me jump! (laughs) Looking back now, maybe it could have been even more flashy and explosive? (laughs)

The nighttime lakeside stone-skipping love scene colours actually use the "rainy flower field" colour direction from episode 19. When I happened to try the colour sample on this scene's art board, it fit perfectly, so we adopted it. There was almost no reuse (←unpleasant way to put it (laughs)) like this - maybe 1-2 times in other episodes.

The final cut of Casshern being trampled. We created Casshern's rough feeling by compositing diagonal line materials that Kimura-kun roughly sketched with pencil over the finished colouring. It's not an expression method you can use for everything, but I feel it really suits Casshern's style, and I quite like it.

...That was episodes 19, 20, and 21.

And about episode 22...

"I'll do the final three episodes 22, 23, 24 myself!" Director Yamauchi's bombshell declaration! Despite the production schedule being so tight already, having Director Yamauchi handle storyboard + direction for all of the last three episodes himself - in a way reckless and extremely dangerous, such thrilling developments were secretly in progress...

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